

Instructional Strategy & Approach

Digital Literacy Fundamentals — Why This Course Is Built the Way It's Built

1. Guiding Frameworks

Framework	What It Says	Where It Shows Up in This Course
Adult Learning Theory (Andragogy)	Adults learn best when content connects to their own goals, they have autonomy over pace, and material has clear relevance to their lives.	Orientation lesson frames the entire course around a concrete outcome (a job application, an interview) rather than an abstract skill. Self-paced throughout, no forced timing.
Trauma-Informed Design	Prioritizes physical and emotional safety, choice, and control. Removes mechanisms that mimic institutional control wherever they're not essential to learning.	No visible attempt tracking anywhere in the course, including the capstone. No comparative or competitive elements. Errors in the simulation are recoverable with no penalty and no record.
Cognitive Load Theory	Working memory is limited. Instructional design should minimize load that doesn't serve learning so capacity stays available for the actual skill being taught.	Each lesson isolates one skill domain. The input-model decision (tap instead of simulated cursor, see Task & Content Analysis, Section 4) is itself a direct cognitive-load decision — removing an unnecessary motor-translation step so the learner's attention stays on the concept being taught.
Gagné's Conditions of Learning	Different learning domains — motor skill, verbal information, intellectual skill — require different instructional conditions to be learned effectively.	Task & Content Analysis, Section 2, classifies every skill by domain. Lessons 2–5 pair each skill with the instructional method its domain requires — modeling and guided practice for motor skills, explicit naming for verbal information, varied-example discrimination for intellectual skills — rather than teaching all skills the same way.

2. Course Structure Rationale

Why five teaching lessons plus a separate capstone, instead of one long module

Bundling all four skill domains into a single module (the original approach considered) would front-load more new interaction risk than a first-time device user should face before they've built any confidence. Splitting into discrete lessons — one per skill domain, each low-risk (illustrated/accordion-style, not yet hands-on) — lets the learner build vocabulary and conceptual understanding before ever being asked to perform the skill live. The capstone is where performance is actually asked for, once every prerequisite concept has already been introduced separately.

Why the capstone comes last, not distributed across each lesson

Per the prerequisite hierarchy in the Task & Content Analysis, several capstone tasks (switching windows, using the taskbar) depend on concepts from more than one earlier lesson. Placing hands-on simulation practice inside each individual lesson would mean the learner attempts a compound task (e.g., “click an icon to open a window”) before

every component skill has been introduced. Reserving the full simulated environment for the end lets every capstone task draw on knowledge the learner has already had explained to them at least once, lowering the odds of a first attempt at any skill happening under performance conditions.

Why static/illustrated teaching before interactive practice, not interactive-first

A first-time device user's very first exposure to tapping and dragging should not happen inside a simulation with no explanation — that reverses the order Cognitive Load Theory and Gagné's conditions both call for (exposure and explanation before guided practice, guided practice before independent performance). Lessons 2–5 use the same accordion/illustrated pattern already established and validated in this portfolio's other courses; only the capstone asks for live performance.

3. What This Approach Deliberately Avoids

Common Approach	Why It's Avoided Here	What's Used Instead
A single combined module covering all four skill domains at once	Bundles unrelated motor and conceptual skills together, increasing cognitive load and giving the learner no natural stopping point to build confidence before the next domain.	Four discrete lessons, one per domain, sequenced by the prerequisite hierarchy.
A simulated on-screen cursor the learner drags with a finger	Adds a second, unfamiliar motor skill (finger-to-cursor translation) on top of the actual concept being taught — extraneous load, and a new failure mode unrelated to the skill itself.	Direct tap interaction, paired with explicit real-laptop-equivalent labeling. See Task & Content Analysis, Section 4.
Scored quizzes or pass/fail gates between lessons	Introduces a visible, comparable performance record that conflicts with the trauma-informed, non-punitive pacing principle already established across this portfolio.	Untimed, ungated progression. The capstone measures completion of tasks, not a pass/fail score.
Framing the course as remedial (“catch up on basic tech skills”)	Risks shame-based motivation for a population where visible skill gaps carry more weight than for a general adult learner — see Needs & Audience Analysis, Section 5.	Framing tied to a concrete, learner-owned goal (a job, an interview), introduced explicitly in the Orientation lesson.

4. Traceability

Every choice in this document traces back to either a finding in the Needs & Audience Analysis, a skill classification or dependency in the Task & Content Analysis, or an objective stated in the Learning Objectives document. Where a design choice doesn't map back to one of those three, it's a style preference, not a strategy, and worth flagging for review rather than assumed correct by default.